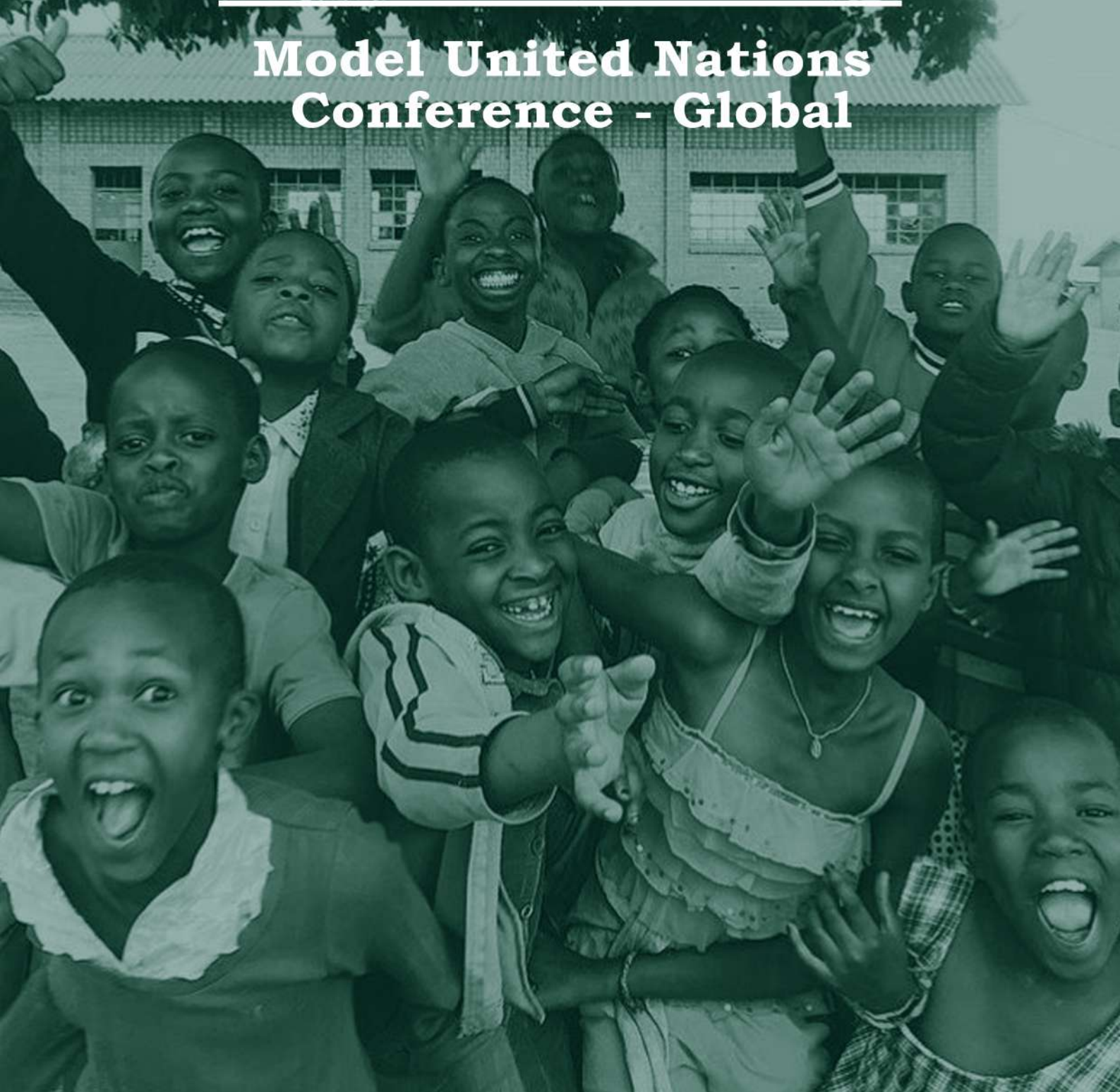




SOCHUM

SOCIAL, HUMANITARIAN AND CULTURAL COMMITTEE

**Model United Nations
Conference - Global**



FROM THE COMMITTEE BUREAU

Distinguished delegates,

The Social, Humanitarian and Cultural Committee bureau welcomes you to MUNCGLOBAL's flagship conference in Ghana, MUNC-GH. We are pleased to have you discuss the crucial theme "Combating Misinformation & Protecting Democratic Processes."

This background guide is designed to introduce you to the topic and the committee's mandate. We encourage you to review this material carefully and conduct further research on the global dynamics of misinformation, media, and democracy. Your role is to represent your country's perspective thoughtfully, drawing on your knowledge of international efforts and human rights.

SOCHUM is a forum for open, respectful debate. We expect all delegates to engage constructively, listen to different viewpoints, and work cooperatively toward solutions. During committee sessions, you will deliver speeches, negotiate in caucus, and draft resolutions. The Bureau will assist by organizing the agenda, managing debate, and clarifying procedures. We look forward to your diligent preparation and active participation. Together, you will help develop recommendations that balance the protection of free expression with the need to safeguard fair electoral and democratic processes. On behalf of the Bureau, I wish you a productive and enlightening session.

TOPIC BACKGROUND

In the digital age, false or misleading information has become ubiquitous. Misinformation (false content shared without intent to harm) and disinformation (deliberately deceptive content meant to mislead) spread rapidly through social media, messaging apps, and even traditional media. This “information pollution” travels at global speed. Social media algorithms often prioritize sensational or emotionally charged content, creating echo chambers of like-minded users. Automated bots and coordinated online networks can further amplify bogus narratives, sometimes even swaying public opinion during elections. In addition, there are strong economic and political incentives: sensational falsehoods tend to attract more views and engagement, which generates advertising revenue, so both content creators and platforms can profit from spreading misinformation. Human psychology also plays a role – for example, people are prone to confirmation bias (accepting information that fits their beliefs) and may not fact-check viral posts before sharing. All these factors fuel the global spread of deceptive content.

Media and Technology: Social media platforms personalize each user’s feed based on past behavior, often showing them more of what they click on. This can hide opposing viewpoints and reinforce preexisting opinions. In practice, users see an incomplete, curated view of information. The result is that sensational or divisive messages (even if false) tend to spread faster, and networks of false content can form “echo chambers” that isolate groups from corrective information.

Automated Campaigns: Internet “bots” (automated accounts) and troll farms can post large volumes of false or misleading posts in a coordinated way. For example, journalists have documented that some bot-driven campaigns have aimed to influence elections in multiple countries. Such coordinated activities flood social media with misleading narratives (sometimes using fake accounts impersonating real people or AI-generated audio/videos), making it difficult for ordinary users to distinguish truth from falsehood.

Economic/Political Motives: Individuals or organizations may deliberately create and share misinformation for profit or power. Because false news can go viral more easily, content creators (and even platforms themselves) may earn more advertising or branding revenue from provocative misinformation. Similarly, political actors may use disinformation to smear opponents or manipulate public opinion. In sum, misinformation is not new, but modern digital tools have made it much easier to produce and disseminate widely in minutes.

The consequences of unchecked misinformation can be severe for democracy. A free and fair democratic system depends on an informed electorate and trust in institutions. When large numbers of citizens receive conflicting or false information, public trust erodes. Societies become polarized as people retreat into opposing “information bubbles”. According to observers, propaganda and fake news “ultimately ... undermine democracies and reduce trust in democratic processes”. In real-world terms, misinformation can cast doubt on election results, fuel rumors of fraud, or even incite unrest.

Global surveys confirm the anxiety: a 2023 poll across sixteen countries found that 85% of people worry about the influence of online disinformation and 87% say it has already seriously affected their nation's politics. In other words, most citizens see false information as a direct threat to governance. Social media is repeatedly cited as the main source of "fake news" and many voters demand action: in that same survey, nearly 90% of respondents urged their governments and tech platforms to step up efforts to combat disinformation, especially during election campaigns.

Regionally and locally, examples abound. In Ghana's 2024 national elections, for instance, fact-checkers documented a wave of false and polarizing narratives. Weeks before voting, social media were flooded with fake audio recordings and posts claiming to expose secret plots or corruption by presidential candidates. These fabricated stories aimed squarely at influencing public perception and the perceived legitimacy of the vote. In response, Ghanaian media groups formed a Fact-Checking Coalition to monitor and debunk rumors in real time. This coalition set up "situation rooms" to track misleading claims on social networks and issue corrections to the public. Such efforts illustrate one way civil society tries to counteract disinformation, but they also highlight how sophisticated and timely misinformation can be.

Recognizing these dangers, international bodies and experts have raised the alarm. UNESCO's Director-General has warned that false information and online hate speech, amplified by social networks, pose "major risks to social cohesion, peace and stability"

Many countries are considering new laws or regulations (such as transparency rules for political ads, higher penalties for malicious botnets, or digital literacy programs in schools) to protect electoral integrity. However, it is widely agreed that any response must balance the need to restrict harmful falsehoods with the protection of free expression rights. The United Nations and its partners emphasize a holistic, human-rights-based approach: strengthening media literacy, supporting independent journalism, and encouraging fact-based public education are seen as crucial steps to help citizens recognize and reject misinformation.

In summary, misinformation has become a global challenge in the information age. It is driven by social media and economic incentives, affects societies worldwide, and has clear implications for democratic legitimacy. Delegates should consider both the technological roots and the human impact of false information. The goal is to find ways to combat misinformation—through education, policy, and cooperation—while upholding the democratic values of transparency and free speech.

COMMITTEE BACKGROUND

The Social, Humanitarian and Cultural Committee is the General Assembly's Third Committee, one of six main GA committees. SOCHUM's mandate covers a broad range of social and human rights issues. In practice, the committee focuses on human rights, humanitarian affairs and social matters. Its agenda typically includes topics such as gender equality and women's empowerment, the welfare of children and youth, refugee and migrant protection, indigenous peoples' rights, the treatment of persons with disabilities, education and cultural preservation, and the promotion of fundamental freedoms (like freedom of expression and belief).

Misinformation and the protection of democratic processes intersect with SOCHUM's work in several ways. For example, freedom of expression and access to accurate information are considered fundamental human rights. When falsehoods spread unchecked, they can lead to hate speech, discrimination or violence against vulnerable groups—issues squarely within SOCHUM's purview (e.g. refugees or ethnic minorities targeted by disinformation). Likewise, cultural and educational aspects are relevant: the committee addresses issues like media literacy and open access to information, which are key to preventing the harm caused by fake news. In essence, SOCHUM deals with the social and rights-based dimensions of communication and education that affect democratic participation.

Notably, SOCHUM serves as a forum to discuss these topics at the international level. It often reviews reports from UN human rights bodies and agencies.

Each session typically includes presentations or interactive dialogues with the UN High Commissioner for Human Rights and the High Commissioner for Refugees. This means delegates hear expert perspectives on issues like press freedom, minority rights, and refugee protection—contexts in which misinformation can have serious impacts. For instance, if false information targets migrants or stokes xenophobia, the Third Committee can address that as a human rights concern.

In previous General Assembly sessions, SOCHUM has taken up related challenges. For example, in 2021 and 2022 it considered draft resolutions aimed at preventing disinformation and protecting human rights online. These initiatives emphasize that solutions to misinformation should not involve censorship, but rather should strengthen independent media and fact-based public discourse. As delegates in SOCHUM, you will build on this tradition: examining how false narratives threaten open societies, and how international cooperation (consistent with human rights standards) can help safeguard democratic values.

In summary, SOCHUM's purpose is to examine social and cultural issues through the lens of human dignity and welfare. Combating misinformation fits into this mandate because it is essentially about information integrity and the right to truthful, reliable information—elements that underlie peace, education, and the fair exercise of democracy. Your debate should

reflect this context by considering how policies or initiatives (for example, public education, media policy, or support for independent journalism) can align with SOCHUM's humanitarian and human rights goals while protecting open democratic processes.

COMMITTEE STRUCTURE

SOCHUM is open to all UN Member States, each of the 193 member states appoints a delegate to represent its government's position. Some Observer States and UN agencies may attend and deliver statements, but only Member States have voting rights in drafting resolutions. Each country's delegate speaks on behalf of its nation's views, coordinating with allies or negotiating with opponents to form consensus. SOCHUM meets once a year on topics approved by the UN General Assembly. At MUNC-GH, the main agenda will be the issue of misinformation and democracy. Formal debates follow GA procedures: delegates speak from a speaker's list in turn, addressing the whole committee. Between speeches, delegates hold informal caucus sessions (both moderated and unmoderated) to negotiate and collaborate. These informal sessions are where much of the resolution-writing takes place. Delegates may form drafting groups or "blocs" based on regional or ideological alignment to co-author working papers and draft resolutions on specific sub-issues of the topic.

In summary, SOCHUM is structured like a miniature UN General Assembly focused on social issues. Each country gets a voice, and the Bureau guides the process. Decisions are made with the aim of broad agreement. As a delegate, you will participate in both formal speeches and informal negotiations. Your goal is to craft resolutions that reflect cooperative solutions to misinformation while fitting within SOCHUM's rules and mandate. We encourage you to familiarize yourself with UNGA procedure (speaker's list, motions, voting) and to work diplomatically with other delegations. Together, you will navigate this committee's structure to propose realistic, rights-respecting ways to combat misinformation and strengthen democracy.